“Every problem I have is a spiritual attack.”

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Where it often comes from

A church culture that blamed the devil for flat tires, illness, and bad moods alike. Frightening teaching about demons that left you watchful and anxious. Wanting an explanation for suffering that does not involve your own choices or ordinary causes. Real experiences of evil that made you suspicious of everything. Feeling helpless, so that an outside enemy seems like the only explanation.

What Scripture teaches

The devil is real, and Scripture tells us to be alert and resist him. But the Bible also names many other causes of trouble: living in a broken world, our own desires and choices, other people’s choices, and the limits of our human bodies. When Elijah was exhausted and despairing, God sent an angel with food and let him sleep. Jesus said we will have trouble in this world, and He has overcome it.

> *“I have told you these things so that in Me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation. But take courage; I have overcome the world!”* **(John 16:33)**.

Also see

> “When tempted, no one should say, ‘God is tempting me.’ For God cannot be tempted by evil, nor does He tempt anyone. But each one is tempted when by his own evil desires he is lured away and enticed” **(James 1:13–14)**.

> “Then he lay down under the broom tree and fell asleep. Suddenly an angel touched him and said, ‘Get up and eat.’ And he looked around, and there by his head was a cake of bread baked over hot coals, and a jar of water. So he ate and drank and lay down again” **(1 Kings 19:5–6)**.

> “For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust” **(Psalm 103:14)**.

> “Be sober-minded and alert. Your adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour. Resist him, standing firm in your faith and in the knowledge that your brothers throughout the world are undergoing the same kinds of suffering” **(1 Peter 5:8–9)**.

Common self-statements

- The enemy is behind everything that goes wrong.
- If I’m tired or sad, I’m under attack.
- I have to fight spiritually every time something breaks.
- This illness must be demonic.
- Nothing bad ever happens by accident.
- My choices have nothing to do with my problems.

Common logical errors

- **Overgeneralization:** Turning “the devil sometimes attacks” into “every problem is an attack.”
- **Jumping to conclusions:** Deciding the cause before looking at ordinary explanations.
- **Externalizing:** Placing all responsibility outside yourself, so nothing can be changed.

- **Catastrophizing:** Reading a dark spiritual meaning into everyday trouble.
- **Mental filter:** Overlooking physical, emotional, and practical causes.

Challenging questions

- What ordinary causes could explain this problem?
- Did Jesus say trouble would come only from the devil, or from living in this world?
- When Elijah despaired, what did God give him first?
- Is there any part of this I can change by my own choices?
- Could this be my body asking for rest, food, or medical care?
- Does blaming the enemy for everything make me more fearful or more faithful?
- How can I resist the devil without seeing him behind every problem?

Truth summary

> Not every problem is a spiritual attack. Some trouble comes from a broken world, some from my body, some from my own or other people's choices, and sometimes from the enemy. I can stay alert without living in fear. Jesus has overcome the world, and I can take each problem to Him and deal with it wisely.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Devil
- Troubles
- Hardship
- Wisdom
- Evil, Resisting

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Suffering
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Every problem I have is a spiritual attack"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Every problem I have is a spiritual attack." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What ordinary causes could explain this?
- ☐ What did Jesus say about trouble in this world?
- ☐ What did God give Elijah first?
- ☐ Is there any part of this I can change?
- ☐ Could my body need rest, food, or care?
- ☐ Does blaming the enemy make me more fearful?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Trouble is part of life in this world, and Jesus has overcome it.
- ☐ Not every problem is a spiritual attack.
- ☐ I can stay alert without living in fear.
- ☐ God cares for my body as well as my soul.
- ☐ I can take each problem to Jesus and handle it wisely.
- ☐ Greater is He who is in me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **John 16:33**
  "I have told you these things so that in Me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation. But take courage; I have overcome the world!"
- [ ] **James 1:13–14**
  "When tempted, no one should say, 'God is tempting me.' For God cannot be tempted by evil, nor does He tempt anyone. But each one is tempted when by his own evil desires he is lured away and enticed."
- [ ] **1 Kings 19:5–6**
  "Then he lay down under the broom tree and fell asleep. Suddenly an angel touched him and said, 'Get up and eat.' And he looked around, and there by his head was a cake of bread baked over hot coals, and a jar of water. So he ate and drank and lay down again."
- [ ] **Psalm 103:14**
  "For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust."
- [ ] **1 Peter 5:8–9**
  "Be sober-minded and alert. Your adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour. Resist him, standing firm in your faith and in the knowledge that your brothers throughout the world are undergoing the same kinds of suffering."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Cause log:** When a problem comes, write it down with three possible causes: physical, practical, and spiritual. Then write one wise step.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, John 16:33 becomes: "I have told **Sarah** these things so that in Me **she** may have peace. In the world **she** will have tribulation. But take courage; I have overcome the world!"*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Troubles" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Pick one current problem** and list every possible cause before deciding it is spiritual. Choose one practical step and take it.
- ☐ **Take care of your body for three days:** sleep, eat regular meals, and walk, then notice whether "attacks" change.
- ☐ **Read 1 Kings 19:1–8,** and write down how God cared for Elijah's body before speaking to his soul.
- ☐ **Ask a wise Christian friend** how they tell the difference between spiritual warfare and ordinary trouble.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Every problem I have is a spiritual attack": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One wise step I took
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Every problem I have is a spiritual attack.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord Jesus, thank You that You have overcome the world. Help me reject the lie that every problem is a spiritual attack. Give me wisdom to see the real causes of my troubles, courage to take wise steps, and peace in knowing that You are greater than any enemy. In Your name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.